

FIZA BEING TAKEN TO HOSPITAL AFTER SHE ALLEGEDLY ATTEMPTED SUICIDE (LEFT); FIZA READS OUT SMSs SENT BY CHAND AT YET ANOTHER PRESS CONFERENCE IN THE SAGA



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proximity to certain influential Congress leaders. "I can sacrifice anything for my love" was Chand's pet reply when reminded of loss of clout and social opprobrium. Chand's father, former chief minister Bhajan Lal, also disowned him.

Given their diverse backgrounds and the dubious nature of their alliance, not many were surprised when their honeymoon came a cropper so soon. Within two months of the pair unveiling their 'convert-and-consummate' matrimony, their made-for-television sweet shenanigans began turning sour. Last week, it erupted in a series of dramatic sequences when Chand did a vanishing act from their home—a modest flat in Mohali—without informing Fiza who quickly made it out to be abduction, raising an accusing finger at Kuldeep Bishnoi, Chand's brother and Bhajan Lal's heir apparent. "Since we are passing through a hard patch financially, Chand has been lured and kidnapped by Bishnoi's men," she said amid tears. It turned out to be a high-voltage hoax with Chand surfacing briefly in Gurgaon before television cameras to deny his abduction.

Stung by Chand's nonchalance, Fiza feigned suicide by consuming sleeping pills but her antics, apparently aimed at pressuring Chand to

return, didn't have the desired effect. He didn't even bother to call Fiza but chose the media to distance himself from her. Fiza's suicide bid earned her an FIR under Section 309 of the IPC. However, what added insult to injury was Chand's biting byte that he still loves his first wife and their children and longs to return to his family—a U-turn that proved to be the last straw for Fiza, provoking a fiery reaction.

Unleashing a no-holds-barred attack on Chand, she levelled a litany of blackmail-and-betrayal charges against him. "Chand has exploited me physically and emotionally," she thundered, vowing to exact revenge for deserting her. "I have lost my *izzat*, religion and job for him, and got only betrayal and an FIR," she said, while reeling out a stream of SMSs with 'woo-and-wed' overtones that Chand had sent her in the last three years.

The reasons for their fairy-tale marriage hitting the rocks are not hard to understand. Bereft of power, clout and all the trappings of VIP status, Chand found himself reduced to a political non-entity and a social outcast within two months of his second marriage. While his supporters deserted him, even more humiliating

was the withdrawal of security cover by the state Government, forcing him to petition the Punjab and Haryana High Court. Fiza, keen to take a plunge into politics, was pushing him to activate himself politically ahead of the general polls and pressed him to make her a partner in the ancestral property and financial package he had received from his family as part of the parting settlement. According to sources, she has also been egging on him to extract more assets from Bhajan Lal, which finally forced Chand to mend relations with his family.

Despite all her ravings, Fiza is yet to elicit sympathy or support from women's organisations. Also, she has few legal options, considering that Chand can evoke Muslim law to annul the marriage without facing any punitive action. The ruling party may be tempted to use her as a weapon against the Bhajan Lal family in the upcoming Lok Sabha elections, the first electoral test for Kuldeep's fledgling party.

In the 1980s, Bhajan Lal's politics of defection earned the state an enduring epithet of 'Aya Ram Gaya Ram' politics. His son may have done the same in matrimony. Given the controversy the Chand-Fiza saga is embroiled in, the plot has thickened and the last act is yet to play itself out. ■